



Pau d'arco

An evergreen tree (deciduous in cold climates) reaching 100 ft (30 m), with pink flowers.

Tabebuia spp. (Bignoniaceae)

Pau d'Arco (Portuguese), Lapacho (Spanish)

Bark from the pau d'arco tree has been valued for centuries in traditional South American herbal medicine for its remarkable health benefits. Today, it is given as a remedy for inflammatory and infectious problems, including conditions such as chronic fatigue and candidiasis. It is also used for other conditions and has a mixed reputation as a treatment for cancer, including leukemia.



Pau d'arco is valued for its durable wood and for its bark that has important therapeutic properties.

Habitat & Cultivation

An indigenous South American tree, pau d'arco grows well in mountainous terrains. In Peru and Argentina it is found growing high up in the Andes. Pau d'arco is also found in low-lying areas (in Paraguay and Brazil), where it is thought to have originated. Many *Tabebuia* species are used in herbal

medicine, so quality control of dried bark can be difficult. *T. avellanedae* is considered to be the most therapeutically effective species, while *T. impetiginosa* is the species that is most commonly available. Pau d'arco is not normally cultivated—the prized inner bark is collected from trees growing in the wild, throughout the year.

Key Constituents

- Napthaquinones (lapachol)
- Anthraquinones
- Coumarins
- Flavonoids
- Iridoids
- Carnosol

Key Actions

- Antibacterial
- Antifungal
- Antiparasitic
- Immunostimulant
- Anti-inflammatory

- Tonic
- Antitumor

Research

■ **Antibacterial and antifungal activity** A Colombian review (2013) of research data on *Tabebuia* species, much of which was undertaken in South America, highlighted pau d'arco's strong, direct activity against several key bacteria, notably *Staphylococcus aureus* and *Helicobacter pylori*, the latter being the principal cause of stomach ulcers. It also has broad-ranging activity against many fungal agents, including *Candida albicans*.

■ **Antitumor properties** Pau d'arco's anticancer action has been established in laboratory experiments, with many of its constituents suppressing the growth of cancer cells. Research in Brazil in the 1960s raised great hopes that pau d'arco might prove to be a major cancer treatment, but clinical research has failed to produce positive results.

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Early cure-all** The Incas, the Callawayas in Brazil, and other Native South American peoples all prized pau d'arco as a cure-all. They used it to treat a variety of conditions,

including wounds, fever, dysentery, and intestinal inflammation, as well as certain types of cancer and snake bite.

■ **Infections** Given the large number of active constituents in pau d'arco, it is not surprising that this beneficial herb is used in South America and by herbal practitioners throughout the world. It is an important, natural antibiotic for bacterial and viral infections, especially of the nose, mouth, and throat, and is considered helpful for chronic conditions such as CFS (chronic fatigue syndrome). Pau d'arco is also used for fungal conditions, including ringworm and thrush, and is considered especially useful for treating chronic candidiasis.

■ Anti-inflammatory action

Pau d'arco reduces and relieves inflammatory problems, especially in the stomach and intestines. It is used to treat a wide range of other inflammatory conditions, including cystitis, inflammation of the cervix, and prostatitis.

■ **Cancer remedy** Clinical experience in Brazil, combined with its worldwide use by herbalists as a cancer remedy, suggests that pau d'arco may be beneficial in the treatment of cancer, including leukemia. However, more intensive research is needed into its therapeutic value.

Parts Used

Inner bark is prized for its immunostimulant properties. It is used to treat many inflammatory conditions.

Bark has important antibiotic properties



Dried inner bark

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Caution** If taking anticoagulant medication, take pau d'arco only on professional advice. Do not take during pregnancy. Avoid if trying to conceive.



Decoction (to make, p. 291) is a traditional preparation in South America. For candidiasis, drink $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) 3 times a day.



Tincture (to make, p. 292) is suitable for long-term use. For cfs, take 40 drops with water 3 times a day.



Ointment (to make, p. 295). For wounds, apply freely.